The Briggs Budget System

From Walt Briggs, 67. Retired mechanic. Forty years of paychecks that never came even, and one system that finally held. No jargon. No spreadsheets you need a degree to open. You write your number down, you look at it every month, and the money starts behaving.

The one rule

Write your number down. By hand. Every month. The number is what came IN minus what went OUT. If it is negative, we fix the OUT side first — not your life, just the leaks.

Worksheet 1 — The Monthly Budget (one page, every month)

Category	Planned	Actual	Difference
Housing (rent/mortgage, insurance)			
Utilities (power, water, phone, internet)			
Food (groceries only)			
Eating out			
Transport (fuel, repairs, insurance)			
Debts (minimum payments)			
Household & personal			
Fun / anything that makes life worth it			
Savings — pay yourself like a bill			
TOTAL OUT			
INCOME IN			
THE NUMBER (in minus out)			

Worksheet 2 — Write Your Number Down (12 months)

Month	In	Out	The Number
Jan			
Feb			
Mar			
Apr			
May			
Jun			
Jul			
Aug			
Sep			
Oct			
Nov			

Dec			

Twelve numbers tell the truth one number hides. A bad month is weather. Three bad months is a leak — find it.

Worksheet 3 — Debt Payoff, Smallest Win First

List every debt smallest balance to largest. Pay minimums on all. Every spare dollar goes on the SMALLEST one until it is gone — a win you can feel — then roll that whole payment onto the next. Momentum beats math for real people.

Debt	Balance	Minimum	Paid off (date)

Worksheet 4 — The Irregular-Income Planner

For paychecks that swing: (1) Find your WORST month of the last year — that is your budget month, not your best. (2) Good months are not raises; the extra goes to the cushion first. (3) Build a one-month cushion in a separate account and pay yourself a steady "salary" out of it on the 1st and 15th. Smooth beats big.

The spreadsheet templates

The companion file briggs-budget-template.csv opens in Google Sheets or Excel with these same four worksheets laid out — type the numbers, the totals add themselves. Print Worksheet 1 and do it by hand at least once. The hand teaches what the screen skips.